1. Leave year, eligibility and balances

1.1 The leave year at Aster Vale Works Pvt. Ltd. runs from 1 January through 31 December. This policy applies to regular full-time and part-time employees on the India payroll. Agency workers, consultants and fixed-term trainees use the time-off terms in their signed engagement letter; they do not receive the balances below unless that letter says otherwise.

1.2 Regular employees accrue leave from their joining date. They may first use accrued leave after completing 90 calendar days of continuous service. The annual paid balances for a full leave year are:

Type	Days per year	Main use
Annual leave	18	Planned personal time away
Sick leave	10	Illness or medical recovery
Personal leave	3	Urgent personal matters

1.3 Part-time balances are prorated to the employee's scheduled workdays and shown in the People Support Desk record. Company-declared public holidays and weekly rest days are not deducted from a leave balance. A half-day absence of four scheduled hours or less uses one half-day; a longer absence uses one full day.

1.4 Annual leave accrues at 1.5 days per completed month, up to 18 days in the leave year. Sick and personal leave are credited on 1 January for eligible employees and are prorated for a joining year. Balances are not cash advances: a request cannot use days that have not accrued or been credited. Employees should check the balance before making non-refundable plans.

1.5 The employee portal is the official balance record. If it differs from a payslip or calendar entry, send the dates and screenshot to people@astervaleworks.example. The People Support Desk confirms a correction in writing; a manager's calendar entry alone does not change the recorded balance.

2. Notice, submission and approval

2.1 Submit each request in the employee portal and identify the leave type, first and last day, and any handoff plan. For annual leave, give at least five working days' notice for one to five consecutive workdays and ten working days' notice for six to ten days. Requests longer than ten consecutive workdays need 20 working days' notice and the additional approval in section 3. Notice is a planning rule, not an automatic approval.

2.2 Give at least two working days' notice for personal leave when the matter can be planned. For an emergency, notify the manager by the normal team channel as soon as safe, then enter the request by the end of the next working day. A request is pending until the required approver records a decision in the portal. Do not treat silence or a calendar hold as approval.

2.3 Managers should decide ordinary requests within three working days. They may ask for a revised date when two people in the same coverage role would be away, a fixed customer duty would be unstaffed, or a documented deadline cannot be handed over. They must explain the scheduling reason and offer a discussion of nearby dates; they must not ask for private medical details to decide annual leave.

2.4 Employees should wait for written approval before booking travel that cannot be changed. When a request is declined, the portal records the reason and the next available dates discussed. The employee may ask the department head to review the scheduling decision within five working days. The department head replies within five working days or gives an expected decision date.

2.5 A change to approved dates is a new request. Submit it as soon as possible and retain the original approval until the manager confirms the change. If a public holiday or weekly rest day falls within a request, those non-working days are excluded from the balance calculation, but the full calendar span should still be shown in the portal for coverage planning.

3. Limits, carry-forward and unpaid leave

3.1 Approval authority is based on consecutive scheduled workdays in one request. The direct manager may approve up to five annual-leave workdays. The department head must approve six to ten days. More than ten and up to 20 consecutive days requires both the department head and the People Operations Director. Split requests that cover one continuous absence are counted together; dividing a request does not change its approval level.

3.2 At 31 December, up to five unused annual-leave days may carry into the next leave year. Carried days must be used by 31 March or they expire. No sick or personal leave carries forward, and those balances have no cash value. Payroll does not pay unused leave during employment. Any final settlement follows applicable law and the employee's written employment terms.

3.3 Once paid leave is exhausted, an employee may request unpaid leave for up to 20 scheduled workdays in a leave year. The manager and department head must both approve it; the People Operations Director must also approve more than ten days. Requests should be submitted 20 working days ahead when foreseeable. Unpaid leave is not guaranteed and may affect pay and benefit calculations under the employee's terms.

3.4 A manager cannot approve an exception to a balance or approval limit. A proposed exception must be sent to people@astervaleworks.example before the absence, with the reason and proposed dates; only the People Operations Director may approve a policy exception in writing, subject to law. No exception can waive an employee's legal rights.

3.5 If two approved absences overlap because of a later operational change, the manager should discuss options with affected employees rather than cancel silently. The People Support Desk can explain the recorded balance but does not replace the designated approver. Keep the approval message until the portal shows the final dates and balance.

4. Illness, emergencies and return to work

4.1 For illness, notify the manager at least one hour before the scheduled shift where possible. If symptoms arise later or make contact impractical, send notice as soon as reasonably possible. Enter sick leave in the portal within two working days after returning. State the dates and expected return date; do not include a diagnosis in a team channel or ordinary leave request.

4.2 A medical certificate may be requested only when sick leave covers more than three consecutive scheduled workdays, or when a repeated absence pattern requires a lawful review. Send documentation directly to people@astervaleworks.example, not to the wider team. The desk limits access to staff who administer leave and records only the information needed to confirm the absence period.

4.3 If an employee becomes ill during annual leave, contact the manager promptly and ask the People Support Desk whether the affected days can be reclassified as sick leave. A medical certificate covering the affected dates is required for reclassification. Until the desk confirms the change, the original annual-leave entry remains in effect. This rule does not extend a trip or create additional sick balance.

4.4 For a family or safety emergency, use personal leave if available and notify the manager as soon as it is safe. If there is no balance, ask about unpaid leave; the usual approval limits still apply. No employee must disclose unnecessary personal details to colleagues. The People Support Desk can explain the private channel for documents or a sensitive request.

4.5 On return, update the portal, confirm the first working day with the manager and review urgent handoffs. Managers must not ask an employee to work while recorded as on approved leave. Questions about a missing balance, certificate or return date go to people@astervaleworks.example. For an urgent same-day absence when the manager is unreachable, contact the department head and copy the desk after the immediate notice.